on his part, replied in the affirmative when asked by Representative Jacob Javits (R-NY) if aid was to help "keep India in the column of the free people." His special assistant, in turn, noted that there were some areas in the world where bread and butter rather than guns and bullets worked better to contain communism. And they would, moreover, also help strengthen the hand of those in the Indian government who were pro-US.[241]

Administration officials worried about the adverse impact of Indian rhetoric and actions on congressional support for aid to India and for foreign aid more broadly. Making the case for India despite its seeming intransigence, US officials like Assistant Secretary George McGhee argued, "India is too important to us and Nehru too important to India for us to take the easy road of concluding that we cannot work with Nehru. We must work with him."[242] Many in the US public agreed. In October 1951, two-thirds of respondents asserted that the US should continue to try to cooperate closely with India despite India's disagreement with America's China and Korea policies.[243]

India's need for aid meant it had an interest in maintaining a working relationship with the US as well. Thus Nehru tried to minimize the impact of differences on his visit to the US in 1949.[244] Later, in December 1950, the Indian finance minister acknowledged that India's request for food aid indicated formal recognition that India needed the US for its major objective: peace and stability.[245] The food minister bluntly noted to a US official, "We have got to have American help."[246] At the time, while the Soviet Union had offered food aid, only the US could provide the quantity that India needed, at the speed India wanted, and on terms India preferred. Policymakers were also cautious about accepting Beijing's offers of assistance since promises of grain repeatedly fell short because of either China's terms or its domestic needs. Furthermore, Beijing's offers of grain were a double-edged sword for the Indian government: they helped to a limited degree, but they simultaneously constituted a propaganda coup for China's alternate system.[247] Finally, Indian policymakers realized that the acceptance of "red rice" might have an adverse impact on its position in the US—this contributed to India's relative silence on its grain negotiations with China.[248]

Indian officials also understood that the broader narrative could affect aid policy. Thus, in spring 1951, as the food assistance bills worked their